

Read: Luke 21:25-36

Christmas Isn't the Only Thing on the Way

Luke 21:25-28

[Jesus said] "There will be signs in the sun, moon and stars. On the earth, nations will be in anguish and perplexity at the roaring and tossing of the sea. People will faint from terror, apprehensive of what is coming on the world, for the heavenly bodies will be shaken. At that time they will see the Son of Man coming in a cloud with power and great glory. When these things begin to take place, stand up and lift up your heads, because your redemption is drawing near."

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

December is here! Stores have been selling Christmas gifts and decorations for months. Parents are figuring out the schedule around holiday parties, winter break, family get-togethers, and additional worship services throughout the month. Radio stations have changed their programming to cycle through carol after carol. Look around; it's undeniable that Christmas is coming!

But in our Bible reading for today, Jesus tells us to look for other signs. Not signs that show the coming of Christmas, which is the first time Jesus came to this world; Jesus also tells us to look for signs that show his coming again. In the Christian Church, we call this season "advent," an old Latin word that means coming. December is a month of anticipation, and we have the privilege of anticipating two things: the celebration of Christ's first coming and the arrival of his second coming as well.

Just like our joyful anticipation of the Christmas holiday, our waiting for Christ's second coming is full of joy, too. The signs of his coming might not sound super joyful because up until that day, sin will continue to affect us and the world. But yes, when we see these signs, we Christians have the joy of standing up and lifting our heads to look for Jesus. We know that he is coming, and that when he finally arrives, he will completely destroy the effects of sin that we've lived with all our lives. He is coming to undo everything the devil ever did. He is coming to take you to be with him in heaven forever!

Keep on watching and waiting—not just to celebrate Christ's first coming, but to joyfully anticipate the second time he comes. That will be a worldwide celebration, unlike any holiday we've ever celebrated.

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- When Jesus comes again, where is he taking us?
- What's the coolest thing about heaven?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- What is the real reason that Christmas is so joyful?
- Why is Christ's second coming going to be even more joyful?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- Jesus' warnings don't sound all that joyful today. Where is the joy as we wait for his second coming?
- Not everyone knows or believes that Jesus is coming again...but he is, whether they think so or not. What does that motivate us to do?

Closing Prayer:

Lord Jesus, you have prepared us to watch and wait for your second coming. In this holiday season, direct our eyes not only to the cradle of your birth but also to the skies of your return. In your name, we pray. Amen.